Predicting NFL Team Performance

Using Draft Data and Past Team Performance

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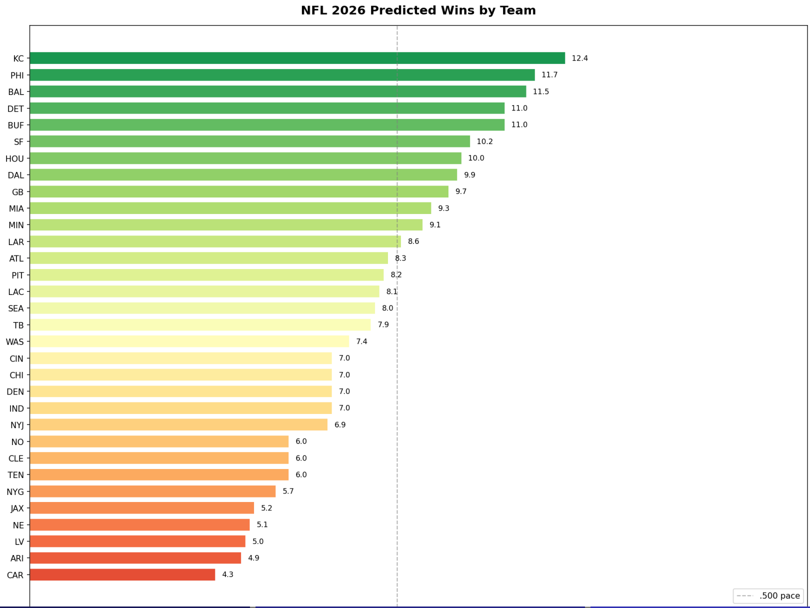
Project Goal

- Our project focused on predicting how NFL teams may perform in 2026.
- We used last season performance data along with draft-related data.
- The main goal was to see which factors had the strongest impact on predicted wins.

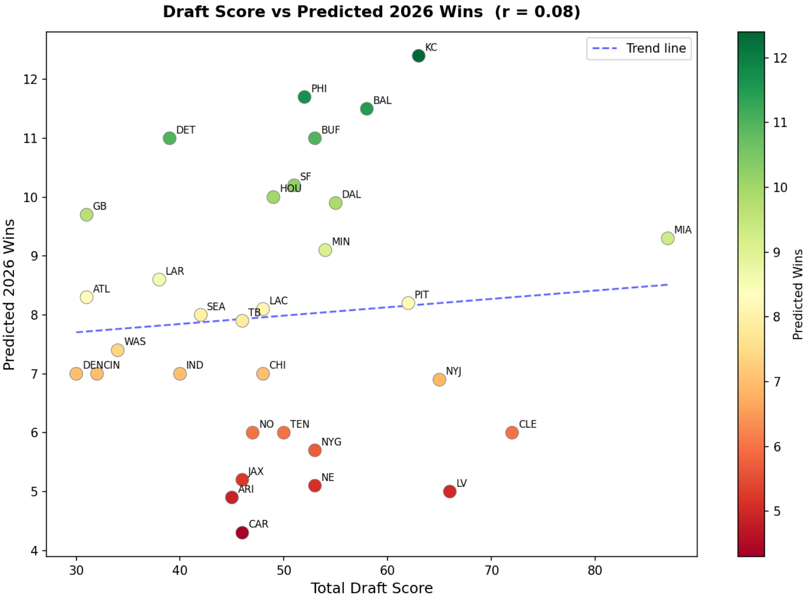
Predicted 2026 Wins by Team



Talking Points: Predicted Wins

- The model predicts teams like KC, PHI, and BAL to perform near the top.
- Lower-performing teams from last season are still projected near the bottom.
- This gives a clear picture of expected team strength going into 2026.

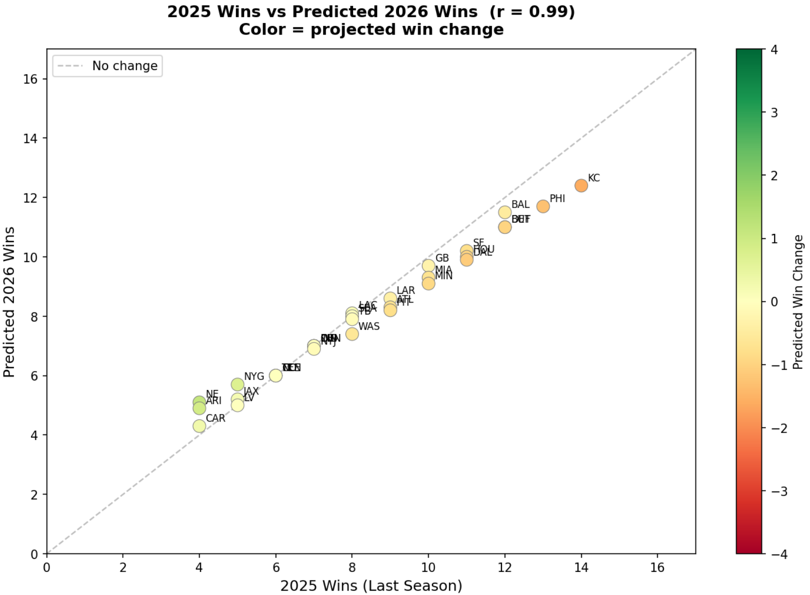
Draft Score vs Predicted Wins



Talking Points: Draft Score

- The relationship between draft score and predicted wins is very weak.
- The correlation value is only $r = 0.08$.
- This suggests draft results alone are not enough to predict team success.

2025 Wins vs Predicted 2026 Wins



Talking Points: Past Performance

- This plot shows a very strong relationship between 2025 wins and predicted 2026 wins.
- The correlation value is r = 0.99.
- Based on our model, past team performance was the strongest predictor.

Main Takeaway

- Our biggest takeaway was that draft results matter, but they do not tell the full story.
- Teams that performed well last season are more likely to be projected higher.
- A better prediction comes from combining draft data with team performance data.

What We Learned

- We learned how to use data visualizations to explain a real sports prediction problem.
- We also learned that one variable by itself usually is not enough to explain team success.
- This project showed us how Python can turn raw data into useful talking points.